

Ararat Gocmen

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RESEARCH INTERESTS

Primary: labor, finance, immigration, entrepreneurship

Secondary: applied, inequality, history

DOCTORAL STUDIES

University College London (UCL) – MRes, MPhil, and PhD in Economics

2027 (expected)

Dissertation: “Essays in Labor and Finance”

Dissertation committee and references:

Professor Christian Dustmann
UCL Department of Economics
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Professor Uta Schönberg
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Professor Saleem Bahaj
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Drayton House, 204
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Clara Martínez-Toledano
Imperial College Business School
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PRIOR EDUCATION

Queen Mary University of London & University College London (jointly awarded)

2021

MA in History of Political Thought and Intellectual History, distinction

Dissertation: “National Difference in the Political Thought of Turkish-Armenian Workers in Postwar Germany”

University College London

2020

MSc in Economics, distinction

Dissertation: “The Impact of Immigration along the Distribution of Native Wages: Evidence from 2000s Germany”

Princeton University

2017

AB in History, Certificate in European Cultural Studies, *summa cum laude*

Dissertation: “The Age of Extremes in Colonial Context: The Mass Politics of Left and Right in Algiers, 1935-1939”

PERSONAL INFORMATION

Citizenship: United States of America

Languages: English, Armenian, Turkish (native); French, Italian (intermediate); German (beginner)

Skills: Stata, MATLAB, Python, R, SQL

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

ROCKWOOL Foundation Berlin (RFBerlin) – Research Fellow

2026-present

Centre for Research and Analysis of Migration (CReAM) – Research Officer

2020-present

BlackRock Solutions Portfolio Analytics Group – Analyst

2017-2019

Predata – Analyst Intern

2016

European Roma Rights Centre – Legal Intern

2015

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

ECON0121 – Economic History: BSc, Professor Ramin Nassehi	2024-2026
ECON0062 – Topics in Labor Economics: MSc, Professor Christian Dustmann	2023-2024
ECON0050 – Economics of the Public Sector: BSc, Professors Silvia Dal Bianco and Lucas Conwell	2022-2023

AWARDS, GRANTS, HONORS & SCHOLARSHIPS

Best Paper Award in Labor and Public Economics at the Asia Meeting of the Econometric Society-China	2026
Stone Centre at UCL PhD Scholarship	2025
Peggy and Richard Musgrave Prize for the best paper presented at the IIPF Annual Congress	2025
Mercatus Center Adam Smith Fellowship	2024
Stone Centre at UCL External Research Support Grant (£50,000)	2023
UCL Faculty of Social and Historical Sciences Dean's List – MRes in Economics	2022
UCL Department of Economics MSc Prize for the strongest record in department work	2020
UCL Department of Economics Outstanding Dissertation Prize	2020
UCL Faculty of Social and Historical Sciences Dean's List – MSc in Economics	2020
Marshall Scholarship	2019
Phi Beta Kappa Society	2017
Gamma Kappa Alpha National Italian Honor Society	2017
Princeton Department of History Laurence Hutton Prize for the strongest record in department work	2017
Princeton Department of History Walter Phelps Hall Prize for the best thesis on European history	2017
Princeton Department of French & Italian André Maman Prize for an outstanding thesis on France	2017
Princeton Department of History Lawrence Stone and Shelby Cullom Davis Prize for an outstanding record	2016
Princeton Shapiro Prize for Academic Excellence	2015

INVITED PRESENTATIONS

2026: Armenian Economic Association XVI Annual Meetings, CSEF-CEPR Conference on Labor and Finance, Asia Meeting of the Econometric Society-China, World Inequality Conference, Migrations & Organizations Conference, UCL Centre for Finance Research Half Day, RFBerlin Migration Forum

2025: Labor and Finance Group Conference, CEPR Paris Symposium, UCL Applied Microeconomics PhD Research Day, NBER Public Economics Program Meeting, Northern Finance Association Conference, RFBerlin-CReAM Workshop, European Economic Association Annual Congress, NBER Summer Institute Household Finance, 11th Conference of the Society for the Study of Economic Inequality, Armenian Economic Association XV Annual Meetings, EU Tax Observatory Workshop on the Economics of Taxation, European Association of Young Economists Annual Meeting, Lake District Workshop in Corporate Finance, RFBerlin Migration Forum

2024: Asian and Australasian Society of Labor Economics Conference, Madrid Public Economics Workshop

INVITED PROGRAMS

NBER Entrepreneurship Research Boot Camp	2025
UC Berkeley Stone Center Summer Institute	2023

WORKING PAPERS

“Private Capital Markets and Inequality” – Under Review ([SSRN](#), [CEPR](#), [RFBerlin](#), [VoxEU](#))
with Clara Martínez-Toledano (*Imperial*) and Vrinda Mittal (*UNC-Chapel Hill*)

This paper examines how expanding private capital markets contribute to rising economic inequalities in the U.S. We show that the share of early-stage financing raised from U.S. high-net-worth individuals (HNWIs) tripled from 2004 to 2022. Exploiting the expansion of the qualified small business stock (QSBS) tax exclusion, we find that HNWIs' investments made startups 5.6% more likely to stay private. Counterfactual simulations reveal that HNWIs' excess returns on early-stage investments explain 26% of the growth in the top 0.5% wealth share over 2010-2022. Finally, investor entry increased incumbents' returns and encouraged further investments, generating a self-reinforcing feedback loop between private capital market growth and inequality.

WORKS IN PROGRESS

“Immigration and Firm Investment” – Job Market Paper

When capital and labor are complements in production, firms respond to an increase in the supply of labor by increasing their demand for capital. The shape of the capital supply curve then determines how the capital stock adjusts and, therefore, whether the economy is able to “scale up” to absorb the labor supply shock without incumbent workers having to suffer earnings losses due to greater labor market competition. In this paper, I exploit immigration-induced regional labor supply shocks in Germany from 2010 to 2019 to show that firm-level credit constraints—the availability of financial capital for physical investments—are a key determinant of the capital stock’s adjustment to an increase in labor supply. I find that, while firms with lower ratios of debt to total assets in 2010 increased both their tangible fixed assets and their debt in response to immigration, firms that were already highly indebted neither levered up further nor expanded their capital stocks. Consistent with these findings, I document that, after 2010, the capital-labor ratio declined more sharply among highly indebted firms. Thus, credit constraints contributed to the overall decline in the capital-labor ratio in Germany during the 2010s in response to immigration, potentially exacerbating any negative effects of immigration on incumbent workers’ earnings.

“Immigration and Labor Market Tightness” – Presented at [Sixth World Labor Conference](#)
with Thomas Cornelissen (Essex), Christian Dustmann (UCL, and Uta Schönberg (HKU)

We investigate how the effects of immigration on native workers’ employment and wages depend on the initial tightness of the labor market. We find that, in Germany during the 2010s, increases in immigrant employment caused native employment to decline in initially slack local labor markets, but with little effect on native wages. In contrast, in initially tight local labor markets, we find considerably less negative employment effects but moderately more negative wage effects of immigration. Overall, labor market tightness mitigates the negative effect of immigration on native workers’ earnings, suggesting the importance of aligning immigration policy with macroeconomic policy. We show that our pattern of results is consistent with a search-and-matching model of the labor market effects of immigration, but not with the canonical neoclassical model.

PREDOCTORAL RESEARCH

“Workers’ Demonstrations and Liberals’ Condemnations: The Italian Liberal Press’s Coverage of General Strikes, Factory Occupations, and Workers’ Self-Defense Groups during the Rise of Fascism, 1919-1922.” *Chicago Journal of History*, [Issue 6](#), Spring 2016, pp. 29-43.

This paper documents the evolution of the Italian liberal press’s coverage of workers’ demonstrations from 1919 to 1922. I show that, in response to the persistence of these demonstrations during this period, Italian liberals became increasingly sympathetic to the growing fascist movement in Italy. I analyze articles from the Italian newspapers *La Stampa* and *L’Illustrazione italiana*, treating their coverage of general strikes, factory occupations, and workers’ self-defense groups as indicative of liberals’ reactions to workers’ demonstrations. By tracking changes in the liberal press in this way, I illustrate how working-class radicalism inadvertently contributed to the rise of fascism in Italy.

“Before Class Struggle: Inequality in European Political and Economic Thought, 1516-1848.”

“Otto Bauer’s National-Evolutionary Politics: Cultural Nationalism as Socialist Strategy in Hapsburg Austria.”

“Reinterpreting the Volcker Disinflation: The FOMC’s Anti-Inflationary Resolve (or Lack Thereof?), 1979-1980.”